Class 7 Social Science – Chapter 5: The Rise of Empires

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This chapter is based on the uploaded NCERT PDF, The Rise of Empires (pages 83–115). Below are the important textbook questions and activities, followed by topic-wise questions and answers, all in simple and easy English for Class 7 students.

Chapter topics

1. What is an Empire?
2. Features of an Empire
3. Trade, Guilds and Economic Growth
4. The Rise of Magadha
5. Alexander's Campaign in India
6. The Rise of the Mauryan Empire
7. Chandragupta Maurya and Kautilya
8. Ashoka and the Kalinga War
9. Ashoka's Dhamma and Inscriptions
10. Administration and Life in the Mauryan Period
11. All Textbook Questions and Activities
12. Important Exam Questions and Quick Revision

Topic 1: What Is an Empire?

Q1. What is an empire?

Answer: An empire is a large territory made up of many smaller kingdoms or territories ruled by a powerful emperor.

Q2. What is the difference between a kingdom and an empire?

Answer: A kingdom is usually ruled by a king over a particular territory. An empire includes many territories or kingdoms under one supreme ruler called an emperor.

Q3. What is an emperor?

Answer: An emperor is a powerful ruler who controls a large territory that may include several smaller kingdoms.

Q4. What does the word 'empire' mean?

Answer: The word 'empire' comes from the Latin word imperium, which means supreme power.

Q5. What were the ancient Indian words for an emperor?

Answer: Some words were Samraj, Adhiraja and Rajadhiraja. They referred to a supreme ruler or a king of kings.

Q6. What is a tributary state?

Answer: A tributary state is a smaller kingdom that accepts the authority of an emperor and gives tribute to him.

Q7. What is tribute?

Answer: Tribute is money, gold, grain, animals or other valuable goods given by a smaller kingdom to an emperor as a sign of submission or loyalty.

Q8. Why did rulers try to build empires?

Answer: Rulers tried to build empires to gain power, fame, wealth, military strength and control over important resources and trade.

Q9. How were empires generally formed in ancient times?

Answer: Empires were generally formed when powerful rulers conquered smaller kingdoms through wars and brought them under their control. Alliances and political agreements could also help them expand.

Q10. Why was the capital important in an empire?

Answer: The capital was the main centre of administration, trade and political power. The emperor and important officials managed the empire from there.

Topic 2: Features of an Empire

Q1. What were the main features of an empire?

Answer: The main features were:

1. A powerful emperor with central authority.
2. A large territory containing smaller kingdoms.
3. A strong army.
4. An organised administrative system.
5. Tax collection and law enforcement.
6. Roads and communication networks.

7. Control over trade, currency and resources.
8. Support for art, literature and learning.

Q2. Why did an empire need a strong army?

Answer: An empire needed a strong army to protect its borders, control tributary states, fight enemies and expand its territory.

Q3. What was the role of officials in an empire?

Answer: Officials helped the emperor collect taxes, maintain law and order, manage provinces and carry out government orders.

Q4. Why were roads and waterways important?

Answer: They helped soldiers, traders, officials and ordinary people travel. They also helped transport goods and communicate across the empire.

Q5. How did an emperor control trade?

Answer: An emperor could regulate trade, issue coins, establish weights and measures, and control access to important resources.

Q6. Why did empires support art and literature?

Answer: Art and literature helped preserve culture, spread ideas and display the power and achievements of rulers.

Q7. What was the role of infrastructure in an empire?

Answer: Infrastructure such as roads, buildings and transport networks helped administration, trade and public welfare.

Q8. How was an empire different from a group of independent kingdoms?

Answer: In an empire, one supreme ruler exercised authority over many territories. In a group of independent kingdoms, each king governed his own territory independently.

Topic 3: Trade, Guilds and Economic Growth

Q1. Why was trade important in ancient India?

Answer: Trade helped people exchange goods, earn money, obtain resources and develop contacts with distant regions.

Q2. Name some goods traded in ancient India.

Answer: Textiles, spices, agricultural products, precious stones, handicrafts, luxury goods and animals were important trade goods.

Q3. What were guilds?

Answer: Guilds, known as shrenis, were organised groups of traders, craftspeople, moneylenders or agricultural workers.

Q4. Why did traders form guilds?

Answer: Traders formed guilds to work together, share information, protect their interests and improve their business activities.

Q5. Who led a guild?

Answer: A guild generally had a head, who was usually elected, and an executive group to manage its work.

Q6. What powers did guilds have?

Answer: Guilds could make rules for their members and organise their business activities. They often enjoyed considerable independence in their internal affairs.

Q7. How did guilds help the economy?

Answer: Guilds encouraged cooperation, improved production, supported trade and helped craftspeople and traders organise their activities.

Q8. How did trade help rulers build powerful kingdoms and empires?

Answer: Trade increased economic activity and wealth. Rulers could collect taxes and use the revenue to maintain armies, officials and public infrastructure.

Q9. What is the relationship between agriculture and trade?

Answer: Agriculture produced food and other goods. Surplus products could be sold or exchanged, which encouraged trade and supported towns and cities.

Q10. What does the chapter teach us about local institutions?

Answer: Local institutions such as guilds and village councils could manage their own affairs. A wise ruler allowed them to function independently when they worked well.

Topic 4: The Rise of Magadha

Q1. Where was Magadha located?

Answer: Magadha was located mainly in present-day southern Bihar and some adjoining areas.

Q2. Why did Magadha become powerful?

Answer: Magadha became powerful because of its fertile land, rivers, forests, elephants, iron resources and strong rulers.

Q3. How did rivers help Magadha?

Answer: Rivers provided water for agriculture and helped people transport goods. They also supported communication and trade.

Q4. Why was iron important for Magadha?

Answer: Iron was used to make agricultural tools and weapons. Better tools increased agricultural production, while stronger weapons improved the army's capabilities.

Q5. Why were forests important for Magadha?

Answer: Forests provided timber for buildings and other uses. They also provided elephants, which were important for warfare.

Q6. Who was Ajatashatru?

Answer: Ajatashatru was a powerful early king of Magadha. He played an important role in making Magadha a major political power.

Q7. What helped Magadha expand its territory?

Answer: Strong rulers, a powerful army, natural resources, fertile land and strategic geographical location helped Magadha expand.

Q8. Why is the rise of Magadha important in Indian history?

Answer: Magadha became a dominant power in northern India and prepared the way for the rise of the Mauryan Empire, the first large empire of the Indian subcontinent.

Q9. How did agriculture support the rise of Magadha?

Answer: Fertile land helped produce more food. Agricultural surplus supported larger populations, soldiers, officials and growing towns.

Q10. How did Magadha's natural resources help its army?

Answer: Iron helped produce weapons, forests supplied timber, and elephants were used in warfare. These resources strengthened Magadha's military power.

Topic 5: Alexander's Campaign in India




Angus McBride



Q1. Who was Alexander?

Answer: Alexander was the king of Macedonia who built a vast empire through military conquests. He is also known as Alexander the Great.

Q2. When did Alexander invade northwestern India?

Answer: Alexander's campaign in northwestern India took place around 327–325 BCE.

Q3. Which Indian ruler fought against Alexander?

Answer: King Porus fought against Alexander in the Punjab region.

Q4. What was the result of the battle between Alexander and Porus?

Answer: Alexander defeated Porus, but he respected Porus's courage and allowed him to continue ruling his kingdom under Alexander's authority.

Q5. What did Porus say when Alexander asked how he wished to be treated?

Answer: According to the traditional account given in the chapter, Porus replied, “Like a King.”

Q6. Why did Alexander's soldiers refuse to move further east?

Answer: They were tired, homesick and unwilling to continue fighting after a long military campaign. They also faced difficult conditions and strong resistance.

Q7. Did Alexander conquer the whole of India?

Answer: No. Alexander's campaign was limited mainly to the northwestern part of the Indian subcontinent. His army did not advance to the Ganga plains.

Q8. What happened to Alexander's empire after his death?

Answer: Alexander died in Babylon in 323 BCE at the age of 32. His empire soon broke apart, and his generals and governors established their own kingdoms.

Q9. What was a satrap?

Answer: A satrap was a governor who managed a province of a Persian or Greek empire.

Q10. What was the impact of Alexander's campaign on India?

Answer: Its direct political impact on India was limited, but it encouraged contacts between Greek and Indian worlds, including cultural and commercial exchanges.

Q11. Why is Alexander important in world history?

Answer: Alexander conquered a vast territory and connected many regions of the ancient world. His campaigns helped spread Greek cultural influences and encouraged contacts between different peoples.

Q12. Why did Alexander want to conquer more territories?

Answer: He wanted greater power, fame, wealth and control over more lands and resources.

Topic 6: The Rise of the Mauryan Empire

Q1. What was the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: The Mauryan Empire was a large ancient Indian empire founded by Chandragupta Maurya around 321 BCE.

Q2. Who founded the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Chandragupta Maurya founded the Mauryan Empire.

Q3. What was the capital of the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Pataliputra, in present-day Patna in Bihar, was its capital.

Q4. Who was Chanakya or Kautilya?

Answer: Chanakya, also known as Kautilya, was a political thinker traditionally associated with Chandragupta Maurya and the Arthashastra.

Q5. What was the Arthashastra?

Answer: The Arthashastra is an ancient Sanskrit text on statecraft, administration, economics, diplomacy and military strategy, traditionally associated with Kautilya.

Q6. How did Chandragupta Maurya expand his empire?

Answer: He built a strong army, defeated rival powers and brought many territories under his control.

Q7. Who was Bindusara?

Answer: Bindusara was the son and successor of Chandragupta Maurya. He continued the expansion and consolidation of the Mauryan Empire.

Q8. Who was Ashoka?

Answer: Ashoka was a famous Mauryan emperor and the grandson of Chandragupta Maurya. He is especially known for his inscriptions and his promotion of dhamma.

Q9. Why was the Mauryan Empire important?

Answer: It united a large part of the Indian subcontinent under one administration and encouraged trade, infrastructure, art and architecture.

Q10. What helped the Mauryas build a large empire?

Answer: A strong army, natural resources, efficient administration, taxation, trade networks and capable rulers helped the Mauryas build and maintain their empire.

Important Mauryan Rulers

Ruler	Important contribution
Chandragupta Maurya	Founded the Mauryan Empire.
Bindusara	Continued the expansion and consolidation of the empire.
Ashoka	Promoted dhamma, public welfare and religious tolerance through inscriptions.

Topic 7: Chandragupta Maurya and Kautilya

Q1. Who was Chandragupta Maurya?

Answer: Chandragupta Maurya was the founder of the Mauryan Empire and one of the most important rulers of ancient India.

Q2. What role did Kautilya play in the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Kautilya is traditionally associated with advising Chandragupta Maurya on politics, administration and statecraft.

Q3. What were Kautilya's main ideas about a kingdom?

Answer: Kautilya believed that a kingdom needed:

1. A protected capital and fortified towns.

2. Fertile land and sufficient food.
3. Water resources for agriculture and daily needs.
4. Mines, forests, pastures and other natural resources.
5. Good roads and waterways.
6. A productive economy and a strong administration.

Q4. Why did Kautilya recommend protecting the capital and towns?

Answer: Protected cities helped defend the kingdom against enemies and supported the safety of its people and resources.

Q5. Why did Kautilya give importance to water?

Answer: Water was necessary for agriculture, drinking and other daily activities. A kingdom could not depend only on rainfall.

Q6. Why were roads and waterways important in Kautilya's ideas?

Answer: They supported transport, trade, communication, military movement and administration.

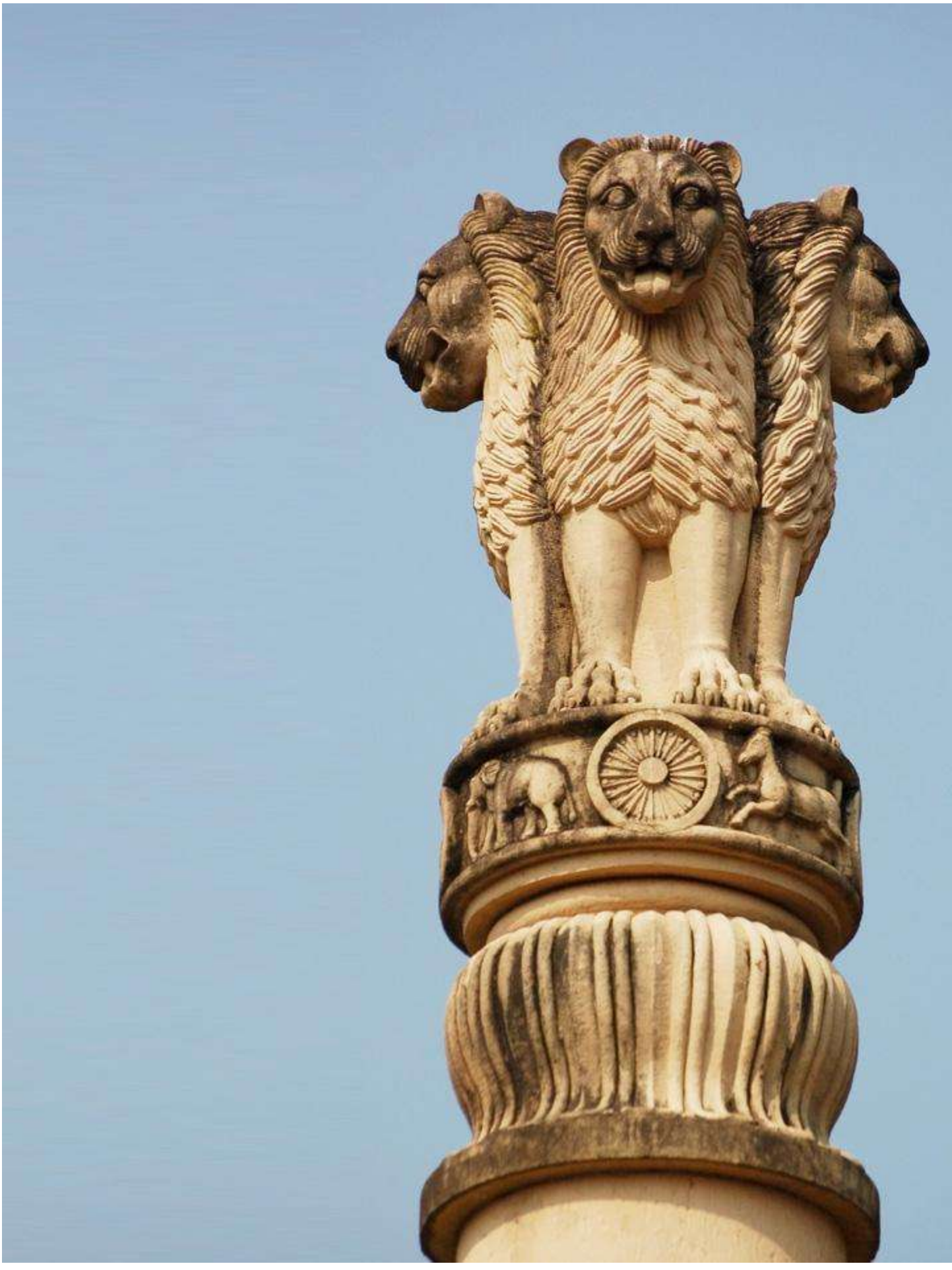
Q7. Which of Kautilya's ideas are useful even today?

Answer: Food security, public safety, water supply, roads, productive economic activity, resource management and good administration are still important for a country.

Q8. Why did Kautilya consider natural resources important?

Answer: Natural resources provided food, building materials, minerals and other goods needed for the economy, the army and the population.

Topic 8: Ashoka and the Kalinga War





Q1. Who was Ashoka?

Answer: Ashoka was one of the greatest rulers of the Mauryan Empire. He is remembered for promoting dhamma, religious tolerance and public welfare.

Q2. What was the Kalinga War?

Answer: The Kalinga War was a major war fought by Ashoka against Kalinga, a region largely corresponding to present-day Odisha.

Q3. Why did Ashoka fight the Kalinga War?

Answer: Ashoka wanted to expand his empire and bring Kalinga under Mauryan control.

Q4. What were the effects of the Kalinga War?

Answer: The war caused great destruction and suffering. Many people were killed, injured or displaced.

Q5. How did the Kalinga War change Ashoka?

Answer: Ashoka was deeply affected by the suffering caused by the war. He began to give greater importance to peace, moral conduct and the welfare of people.

Q6. What is Ashoka's dhamma?

Answer: Ashoka's dhamma was a set of moral principles that encouraged good behaviour, respect for others, kindness, truthfulness and concern for the welfare of all.

Q7. Did Ashoka completely stop governing or maintaining his empire after the Kalinga War?

Answer: No. He continued to govern his empire, but he placed greater emphasis on moral conduct and public welfare.

Q8. How did Ashoka spread his message?

Answer: He had his messages engraved on rocks and pillars across his empire. He also appointed officials known as dhamma-mahamattas to promote dhamma and public welfare.

Q9. Why is Ashoka remembered as an unusual ruler?

Answer: Ashoka is remembered because he openly expressed concern about the suffering caused by war and promoted moral conduct, tolerance and welfare through official inscriptions.

Q10. What can modern leaders learn from Ashoka?

Answer: Modern leaders can learn the importance of peace, fairness, public welfare, religious tolerance and responsible government.

Topic 9: Ashoka's Dhamma and Inscriptions

Q1. What is an inscription?

Answer: An inscription is writing engraved on a hard surface such as stone, metal or a pillar.

Q2. Why did Ashoka use inscriptions?

Answer: Ashoka used inscriptions to communicate his ideas, instructions and achievements to people across his empire.

Q3. What language was used in many of Ashoka's inscriptions?

Answer: Many inscriptions were written in Prakrit.

Q4. What was the Brahmi script?

Answer: Brahmi was an important writing system widely used in ancient India. Many of Ashoka's inscriptions were written in this script.

Q5. What is dhamma-mahamatta?

Answer: A dhamma-mahamatta was an official appointed by Ashoka to promote dhamma and work for people's welfare.

Q6. What did Ashoka want his officials to do?

Answer: He wanted them to be fair, patient, impartial and concerned about the welfare of the people. They were expected to avoid unnecessary imprisonment and torture.

Q7. What does Ashoka's phrase “All men are my children” mean?

Answer: It expresses his concern for the welfare and happiness of his subjects, whom he regarded as people deserving care and protection.

Q8. Was Ashoka tolerant towards other religions?

Answer: Yes. His inscriptions show that he respected different religious communities and encouraged people to treat followers of other beliefs with respect.

Q9. Why are Ashoka's inscriptions important to historians?

Answer: They provide direct historical evidence about his ideas, administration, public welfare measures and attitudes towards war and religion.

Q10. What is the importance of the lion capital of Ashoka?

Answer: The Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath is an important symbol of India's ancient art and heritage. Its representation of four lions forms the basis of India's State Emblem.

Q11. What is the importance of Ashoka's inscriptions today?

Answer: They help us understand ancient Indian history and provide examples of public welfare, moral responsibility and respect for different beliefs.

Topic 10: Administration and Life in the Mauryan Period

Q1. How was the Mauryan Empire administered?

Answer: The emperor ruled from the capital with the help of officials who managed different territories and administrative duties.

Q2. Why did the Mauryan Empire need an organised administration?

Answer: It covered a large territory with many towns, villages and different communities. An organised administration helped collect taxes, maintain order and carry out the emperor's decisions.

Q3. What was the role of taxation?

Answer: Taxes provided revenue to maintain the army, pay officials, support administration and carry out public works.

Q4. What was Pataliputra like during the Mauryan period?

Answer: Pataliputra was a major centre of government and trade. It had palaces, public buildings, busy markets and well-planned streets.

Q5. What was the importance of agriculture during the Mauryan period?

Answer: Agriculture supported most of the population and was an important source of revenue for the empire.

Q6. What does the Sohgaura copper-plate inscription tell us?

Answer: The inscription is one of India's earliest known administrative records. It refers to a granary for storing grain, probably as a measure against famine and food shortages.

Q7. Who was Megasthenes?

Answer: Megasthenes was a Greek ambassador who visited the Mauryan court. His account provides information about Mauryan society and administration.

Q8. What were the main occupations during the Mauryan period?

Answer: Agriculture, trade, crafts, administration and other specialised occupations were important.

Q9. How did coins help the Mauryan economy?

Answer: Coins made trade easier and helped people exchange goods and conduct economic activities over long distances.

Q10. What was the importance of roads in the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Roads helped the movement of traders, officials, soldiers and goods. They also supported communication and administration.

Q11. How did the Mauryas encourage art and architecture?

Answer: They supported monumental structures, pillars, inscriptions and other artistic works. These achievements became an important part of India's cultural heritage.

Q12. What happened to the Mauryan Empire after Ashoka's death?

Answer: The empire continued for about half a century after Ashoka's death. His successors were unable to hold it together, and many smaller kingdoms became independent. Around 185 BCE, the Mauryan Empire came to an end.

Part 11: All Textbook Questions and Activities

The following answers cover the chapter's end-of-chapter questions on pages 114–115 and the important activities and discussion prompts in the earlier sections.

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Question 1. What are the features of an empire, and how is it different from a kingdom? Explain.

Answer:

An empire is a large territory made up of many smaller kingdoms or territories under one supreme ruler. Its main features are a powerful emperor, a strong army, an organised administration, tax collection, roads, trade networks and control over resources.

A kingdom usually has one king who rules a particular territory. An empire is generally larger and includes many territories, sometimes with their own local rulers. These rulers accept the emperor's authority and may pay tribute to him.

Thus, an empire has a wider area of control and a more extensive administrative system than a typical kingdom.

Question 2. What are some important factors for the transition from kingdoms to empires?

Answer:

The important factors were:

1. Powerful rulers who conquered neighbouring kingdoms.
2. Strong armies and effective military strategies.
3. Fertile land and abundant natural resources.
4. Increased agricultural production and revenue.
5. Growing trade networks and economic wealth.
6. Roads and communication systems that connected distant regions.
7. Organised administration to govern large territories.

These factors helped powerful kingdoms expand and develop into empires.

Question 3. Alexander is considered an important king in world history. Why?

Answer:

Alexander is considered important because he conquered a vast territory stretching across parts of Europe, Asia and Africa. His military campaigns brought different regions into contact with one another. His campaign in northwestern India also encouraged contacts between Greek and Indian cultures. Although his empire broke apart after his death, his influence continued in the political and cultural history of several regions.

Question 4. Why are the Mauryas important in early Indian history?

Answer:

The Mauryas are important because they established one of the largest empires in ancient India. They brought many territories under one administration, developed trade routes, used coins extensively and maintained an organised system of government. They also encouraged art and architecture.

Ashoka, the most famous Mauryan ruler, promoted dhamma, religious tolerance and public welfare. His inscriptions provide valuable information about ancient Indian history.

Question 5. What were some of Kautilya's key ideas? Which of these can we observe today?

Answer:

Kautilya believed that a kingdom should have a protected capital, fertile land, sufficient water, mines, forests, good pastures, roads, waterways and a productive economy.

Many of these ideas remain important today. Modern countries need secure cities, food production, water supply, natural resources, good transport, economic development and effective administration. Governments also work to protect people during natural disasters and other emergencies.

Question 6. What were the unusual things about Ashoka and his empire? What has continued to influence India, and why? Write about 250 words.

Answer:

Ashoka was an unusual ruler because he openly expressed regret over the suffering caused by the Kalinga War. After the war, he gave greater importance to peace, moral conduct and public welfare. Instead of relying only on military power, he encouraged people to follow dhamma.

Ashoka's dhamma taught people to be kind, truthful, respectful and fair. He encouraged respect for parents, elders, teachers and different religious communities. He wanted his officials to treat people impartially and avoid unnecessary cruelty.

Ashoka communicated his ideas through inscriptions engraved on rocks and pillars across his empire. These inscriptions are valuable historical sources because they tell us about his policies, administration and views on religion and public welfare.

Ashoka also supported measures intended to improve people's lives. His emphasis on the welfare of his subjects shows that he considered the responsibilities of a ruler to be more than simply conquering new territories.

Several aspects of his legacy continue to influence India. The Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath is the basis of India's State Emblem. The Ashoka Chakra appears at the centre of India's national flag. His emphasis on peace, tolerance, compassion and public welfare also remains relevant.

In my opinion, Ashoka is remembered because he showed that a ruler's greatness does not depend only on military victories. It also depends on the ability to care for people, respect different beliefs and govern with fairness.

Question 7. After reading Ashoka's edict about his officers of dhamma, do you think he was tolerant towards other religious beliefs?

Answer:

Yes, Ashoka showed tolerance towards other religious beliefs. His edict mentions officials who worked with members of different religious communities, including Brahmins, Buddhists, Jains and Ajivikas.

He encouraged respect for different groups and wanted his officials to act fairly. This shows that he valued peaceful coexistence and did not want people to be treated unfairly because of their religious beliefs.

Question 8. Learn about the Brahmi script and prepare a small project.

Answer:

The Brahmi Script

Brahmi was one of the most important writing systems of ancient India. It was widely used during the Mauryan period and appears in many inscriptions of Emperor Ashoka.

Many of Ashoka's inscriptions were written in Prakrit using the Brahmi script. They recorded his messages about dhamma, public welfare, good conduct and respect for different religious communities.

The Brahmi script is important because it helps historians read ancient inscriptions and understand India's past. Many later Indian writing systems developed from Brahmi or from scripts related to it.

Conclusion: The Brahmi script is an important part of India's linguistic and cultural heritage.

Question 9. Suppose you had to travel from Kaushambi to Kaveripattanam in the third century BCE. How would you travel, and how long would it take?

Answer:

I would travel along the ancient routes connecting northern and southern India. I would begin at Kaushambi and travel southwards using routes towards the Deccan and the eastern or southeastern coastal regions. I could travel on foot, use carts where roads permitted, and use boats on suitable rivers.

I would stop at villages, towns and trading centres to obtain food, water and shelter. The journey would take several weeks or even a few months, depending on the route, weather, transport and the length of the daily journey.

This journey would show how ancient roads and trade networks connected distant regions of India.

Part 12: Important Activities from the Chapter

Activity 1. Why did Alexander want to rule the entire world?

Answer: Alexander wanted to gain fame, power, wealth and control over more territories. He also wanted to extend his conquests as far as possible.

Activity 2. Why could satraps exercise considerable power?

Answer: Satraps governed distant provinces on behalf of an emperor. Because the emperor could not directly supervise every region, satraps had considerable freedom to manage local affairs. This could make them powerful and sometimes encourage them to establish independent kingdoms.

Activity 3. What geographical features helped traders travel across India?

Answer: Rivers, plains, mountain passes, valleys and coastal routes helped traders travel. Rivers supported transport, plains provided routes for carts and caravans, and coastal routes connected ports.

Activity 4. What modes of transport were available in ancient India?

Answer: People travelled on foot, on horses and elephants, in bullock carts and on boats. Pack animals also carried goods across long distances.

Activity 5. What can we learn from the Sanchi Stupa panel depicting the siege of a city?

Answer: The panel shows that armies used different methods of warfare. Soldiers fought on foot, on horses and on elephants. They used weapons and surrounded fortified settlements during sieges. It also shows the importance of elephants in ancient warfare.

Activity 6. Why was a parasol placed over the casket containing the Buddha's relics?

Answer: The parasol symbolised respect, honour and sacred status. Placing it over the relics showed reverence for the Buddha.

Activity 7. How could Ashoka's instructions to officials improve administration?

Answer: His instructions encouraged fairness, patience and impartiality. Regular inspections could help ensure that officials followed the rules and avoided unnecessary punishment. This could improve public trust in the administration.

Part 13: Additional Important Exam Questions and Answers

A. Very Short Answer Questions (1 mark)

Q1. Who founded the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Chandragupta Maurya.

Q2. What was the capital of the Mauryan Empire?

Answer: Pataliputra.

Q3. Who was the grandson of Chandragupta Maurya?

Answer: Ashoka.

Q4. Which war changed Ashoka's attitude towards war?

Answer: The Kalinga War.

Q5. What is a guild called in ancient Indian texts?

Answer: Shreni.

Q6. What was the main occupation of most people during the Mauryan period?

Answer: Agriculture.

Q7. What was the name of Ashoka's moral policy?

Answer: Dhamma.

Q8. What is an inscription?

Answer: Writing engraved on stone, metal or another hard surface.

Q9. Who was the Greek ambassador associated with the Mauryan court?

Answer: Megasthenes.

Q10. Around which year did the Mauryan Empire come to an end?

Answer: Around 185 BCE.

Q11. What was a satrap?

Answer: A governor of a province in a Persian or Greek empire.

Q12. Which ancient text is associated with Kautilya?

Answer: The Arthashastra.

B. Short Answer Questions (2–3 marks)

Q1. Explain any three features of an empire.

Answer:

1. An empire controlled a large territory.
2. It had a powerful emperor and a strong army.
3. It maintained an organised administration and collected taxes.

Q2. How did trade contribute to the growth of empires?

Answer: Trade increased wealth and economic activity. Rulers collected revenue from trade and used it to maintain armies, pay officials and build infrastructure. Trade routes also connected distant regions.

Q3. Why was Pataliputra an important city?

Answer: Pataliputra was the capital of the Mauryan Empire. It was a major centre of administration and trade, with palaces, public buildings, markets and well-planned streets.

Q4. What were the main teachings of Ashoka's dhamma?

Answer: Ashoka's dhamma encouraged kindness, truthfulness, respect for parents and elders, religious tolerance, fair treatment of people and concern for public welfare.

Q5. What was the importance of the Brahmi script?

Answer: Brahmi was widely used in ancient Indian inscriptions. It helps historians read Ashoka's messages and understand ancient Indian society, administration and culture.

Q6. How did iron resources help Magadha become powerful?

Answer: Iron was used to make agricultural tools and weapons. Better tools increased agricultural production, while stronger weapons helped the army.

Q7. What was the importance of the Kalinga War?

Answer: The Kalinga War caused great suffering and changed Ashoka's attitude towards conquest. He began to emphasise peace, dhamma and public welfare.

C. Long Answer Questions (4–5 marks)

Q1. Explain the factors responsible for the rise of the Mauryan Empire.

Answer: The Mauryan Empire rose because of several important factors. Magadha had fertile land, rivers, forests, elephants and access to iron resources. These helped increase agricultural production and strengthen the army. Powerful rulers such as Chandragupta Maurya expanded their territories. An organised administration and taxation system helped manage the empire.

Growing trade networks and good transport routes supported economic development. Together, these factors enabled the Mauryas to establish a large empire.

Q2. Describe the main achievements of Ashoka.

Answer: Ashoka was one of the most famous Mauryan emperors. After the Kalinga War, he became deeply concerned about the suffering caused by war. He promoted dhamma, which encouraged kindness, truthfulness, respect for different religions and moral conduct. He communicated his ideas through inscriptions on rocks and pillars. He instructed officials to treat people fairly and work for their welfare. His inscriptions and the Lion Capital of Ashoka remain important parts of India's historical and cultural heritage.

Q3. Explain how an empire was different from a kingdom.

Answer: A kingdom was generally ruled by a king over a particular territory. An empire was larger and included many territories or smaller kingdoms under a supreme ruler called an emperor. Smaller rulers could continue governing their territories but had to accept the emperor's authority and often pay tribute. An empire needed a strong army, an organised administration, taxation, communication networks and control over resources to manage its large territory.

Q4. Describe the importance of trade and guilds in ancient India.

Answer: Trade connected different regions and helped people exchange textiles, spices, agricultural products, precious stones and handicrafts. Guilds, known as shrenis, were organised groups of traders, craftspeople, moneylenders and agricultural workers. They helped members cooperate, share information and manage business activities. Guilds could establish rules for their members. Growing trade increased wealth and revenue, supporting the growth of cities and powerful states.

Q5. How did Ashoka's inscriptions help us understand ancient India?

Answer: Ashoka's inscriptions are important historical sources. They describe his ideas about dhamma, moral conduct, religious tolerance and public welfare. They also provide information about his officials and administration. Many inscriptions were written in Prakrit using the Brahmi script. By studying these inscriptions, historians can learn about Ashoka's policies, his relationship with his subjects and the values he wanted to promote.

Final Revision Table

Important topic	Key fact to remember
Empire	A large territory under a supreme ruler
Tributary	A smaller state that accepts an emperor's authority and pays tribute
Guild	An organised association called a shreni
Magadha	A powerful state in present-day Bihar

Alexander	Campaign in northwestern India around 327–325 BCE
Porus	Indian ruler who fought Alexander
Chandragupta Maurya	Founder of the Mauryan Empire
Kautilya	Thinker traditionally associated with the Arthashastra
Pataliputra	Capital of the Mauryan Empire
Bindusara	Son and successor of Chandragupta Maurya
Ashoka	Mauryan emperor who promoted dhamma
Kalinga War	War that deeply affected Ashoka
Dhamma	Moral principles promoted by Ashoka
Brahmi	Important ancient Indian script
Megasthenes	Greek ambassador associated with the Mauryan court
End of Mauryan Empire	Around 185 BCE

Preparation tip: First learn the definitions and important rulers. Then practise the differences between a kingdom and an empire, the rise of Magadha, Alexander's campaign, and Ashoka's dhamma. Finally, revise the nine textbook questions and practise writing the long answers in your own simple English.